

ParaLife Trees

Planting a Life in Paradise

Peppermint, Spearmint & Black Mint Grow Guide

For true spreading mints - seedlings, small pots, home gardens, and small farmers

WhatsApp: 1 (876) 372-7415

Customer Grow Guide

Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

What You See	Likely Cause	What To Do First
Leaves wilt even though soil is damp	Root rot, poor drainage, or heat stress	Move pot from harsh sun, check drainage holes, let top 1 inch dry before watering again.
Leaves crisping or brown edges	Dry soil, hot sun, small pot drying out	Water deeply, add mulch, move to morning sun/afternoon shade.
Tiny insects under leaves or sticky leaves	Aphids or whiteflies	Spray leaf undersides, repeat every 3-5 days, remove badly infested tips.
Fine webbing or dusty speckled leaves	Spider mites	Rinse undersides, prune worst leaves, avoid drought stress, repeat every 3-5 days.
Orange/brown spots under leaves	Mint rust or fungal disease	Cut affected stems low, remove fallen leaves, improve airflow, avoid overhead watering.
Plant getting long and weak	Too little light or not enough harvesting	Give brighter light and cut stems back by 1/3 to 1/2.
Mint taking over the bed	Runners/rhizomes spreading	Keep in pot or buried container; cut runners before they root.
Leaves losing strong aroma	Old stems, flowering, poor sunlight, too much fertilizer	Harvest young tips often; cut back before/after flowering.

Quick Numbers

Item	Peppermint / Black Mint	Spearmint
Botanical group	Mentha x piperita types	Mentha spicata types
Common harvest maturity	60-70 days from planting/seed stage	60-70 days from planting/seed stage
Plant height	About 1-3 ft	About 1-3 ft
Container minimum	8-10 inch pot; better 12-16 inch wide	8-10 inch pot; better 12-16 inch wide
In-ground spacing	18-24 inches apart	18-24 inches apart
Sunlight	4-6+ hours; protect from harsh afternoon heat	4-6+ hours; handles heat slightly better
Watering target	Keep evenly moist; top 1 inch can begin to dry	Keep evenly moist; top 1 inch can begin to dry
Best harvest length	Cut stems at 4-8 inches or when bushy	Cut stems at 4-8 inches or when bushy
Hard prune	Cut back to 2-3 inches when old/leggy	Cut back to 2-3 inches when old/leggy

Main customer warning: peppermint, spearmint, and black mint spread by runners/rhizomes. Sell and plant them with a containment warning.

Mint Identification and Differences

Mint	How to Identify It	Growing Difference
Peppermint	Darker green leaves, sharp cooling peppermint smell, often darker stems. Black mint is commonly treated as a dark peppermint-type mint.	Likes steady moisture and may prefer a little protection from harsh heat. Strong aroma.
Spearmint	Pointed, slightly crinkled leaves, sweeter chewing-gum/spearmint aroma, usually lighter green than peppermint.	Similar care, often tolerates heat a little better than peppermint.
Black Mint	Dark stems or darker leaf tone depending on strain; strong peppermint smell.	Care is close to peppermint. Keep contained and harvest often.
Costa Rican Peppermint / Jamaican Tree Mint	Small glossy leaves on woody upright bushy stems; not the same as French thyme/Cuban oregano.	Use the separate tree-mint guide. Prune like a small shrub, not like creeping mint.

Sunlight, Soil, and Water

Need	Target
Sunlight	Morning sun plus bright light; 4-6+ hours daily. In hot conditions, give afternoon shade.
Soil	Moist, rich, well-drained soil. Avoid soil that stays soggy.
pH	About 6.0-7.0 is a practical garden target.
Water	Keep evenly moist. Water when the top 1 inch starts to dry.
Drainage	Required. Pots must have drainage holes.
Mulch	Use light mulch to reduce drying and heat stress. Keep mulch off the crown.

- In Jamaica-type heat, mint usually looks best with morning sun and light afternoon shade.
- A small pot dries quickly; a 1 gallon or larger pot is easier for customers.
- Do not leave saucers full of water under pots for long periods.

Feeding Guide

Stage	Timing	Feeding
After settling	7-10 days after transplant	Light liquid feed or compost tea if plant looks pale.
Active growth	Every 3-4 weeks	Light balanced feeding or topdress with compost.
After heavy harvest	Within 3-7 days	Water well and feed lightly if growth slows.
Before flowering	When stems start stretching	Harvest or cut back rather than pushing heavy fertilizer.

Avoid heavy fertilizer. Too much feeding can make mint soft, weak, pest-prone, and less aromatic.

Harvesting Guide

Use	When to Harvest	How to Harvest
Tea or kitchen use	When stems are 4-8 inches and leafy	Cut above a leaf node.
Bushy plant maintenance	Every 7-14 days in active growth	Pinch tips or cut long stems back by 1/3.
Large harvest	When plant is full but before heavy flowering	Cut back to 2-3 inches above soil and let regrow.
After flowering	After flowers fade	Cut back hard to encourage fresh leaves.

- Harvest in the morning after dew dries.
- Use clean scissors or pruners.
- Regular harvesting keeps the plant thicker and younger.

Leaf Color Problem Guide

Leaf Look	Possible Cause	Action
Healthy medium/deep green	Normal growth	Continue steady water and regular harvest.
Pale leaves	Low nutrients, low light, or wet roots	Improve light, check drainage, feed lightly.
Yellow lower leaves	Old leaves, overwatering, crowding	Prune old leaves, improve airflow and drainage.
Brown crispy edges	Dry soil, heat, fertilizer burn	Water deeply, shade afternoon, reduce fertilizer.
Spotted leaves	Fungal disease, rust, water on leaves	Remove affected leaves; water at soil level.
Curled new growth	Aphids, mites, whiteflies, or heat stress	Inspect underside, spray gently, repeat 3-5 days.

Flowering, Runners, and Spread Control

Flowering

- Mint can flower when mature, stressed, or left unharvested.
- Flowers reduce leaf quality; cut flower stems to push fresh leaves.
- After heavy flowering, cut the plant back to 2-3 inches above soil.

Spread Control

- Best customer advice: grow mint in pots.
- If planting in ground, bury a pot/container to slow root spread.
- Keep mint away from vegetable beds where runners can become a weed.
- Trim runners weekly if planting beds are moist.

Small Farmer Notes

- Use container rows, grow bags, or contained beds to stop mint from invading crop areas.
- Space production plants 18-24 inches apart if in ground beds.
- Harvest in batches every 7-14 days for fresh bunches.
- Keep mother plants separate and clean for cuttings.
- Avoid overhead watering late in the day to reduce fungal leaf problems.
- Remove and destroy rust-infected stems; do not use diseased cuttings for propagation.

Home Garden Notes

- For 2-6 plants, pots are best. Use 8-12 inch pots or larger.
- Place where plants get morning sun and afternoon shade.
- Harvest often instead of letting the plant get tall and woody.
- Do not plant directly beside lettuce, basil, or small herbs unless you want mint spreading into them.
- Divide or repot every 6-12 months if roots fill the pot.

Clean Handling and Seedling Sanitation

- Wash hands before handling seedlings, especially after handling tobacco/cigarettes or diseased plants.
- Use clean scissors for harvest and cuttings.
- Do not move from diseased mint plants to healthy plants without washing hands/tools.
- Keep trays and pots off dirty ground where possible.
- Remove fallen leaves from pot surfaces to reduce disease pressure.

Good sanitation protects the customer's mint and also protects nearby tomatoes, peppers, basil, and other crops.

Hardening Off Before Planting

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade for 2-3 hours.
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 2-4 hours.
Day 5-6	Morning sun plus bright afternoon shade.
Day 7	Ready to transplant or repot.

- Keep the root ball moist during hardening off.
- If leaves wilt badly, return plant to shade and water gently.
- Do not move shaded plants straight into full hot sun.

Transplanting From Trays or Small Pots

- Water the seedling 1-2 hours before transplanting.
- Prepare the pot or planting hole before removing the plant.
- Keep the root ball together as much as possible.
- Plant at the same depth as it was in the tray or small pot.
- Water immediately after planting.
- Shade for 1-2 days if the sun is harsh.
- Check morning and evening for the first 3-5 days.

Planting Situation	Spacing / Pot Size
Small pot sale plant	Move to 8-12 inch pot within 2-4 weeks if growing for harvest.
Home container	1 gallon or larger is easier to manage.
In-ground bed	18-24 inches apart, with containment warning.
Production bed	18-24 inches apart; contain roots or harvest aggressively.

Common Pests

Pest	Signs	Action
Aphids	Clusters on soft tips, sticky leaves, curled growth	Spray off; use mild soap solution; repeat every 3-5 days.
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects fly up when touched; yellowing leaves	Spray undersides; use yellow sticky traps; repeat.
Spider mites	Fine webbing, speckled/dusty leaves	Rinse undersides; prune damage; avoid drought stress.
Flea beetles	Tiny holes in leaves	Use netting where possible; remove weeds; keep plants strong.
Cutworms/caterpillars	Chewed leaves or cut stems	Check evenings; handpick; protect young plants.

Common Diseases

Disease	Signs	Action
Mint rust	Orange/brown pustules or spots; leaves decline	Cut affected stems; remove debris; avoid wet foliage; start fresh if severe.
Leaf spot	Brown or black spots, yellowing leaves	Remove affected leaves; improve airflow; water at soil level.
Powdery mildew	White powdery coating	Improve airflow; avoid overcrowding; remove affected growth.
Root rot	Wilting with wet soil; black/brown roots	Improve drainage; reduce watering; repot into fresh mix.

Sources and Support

Need help with your plant? Send clear photos of the full plant, damaged leaves, underside of leaves, soil/pot, and any insects you see.

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Source notes used to prepare this customer guide:

- University of Delaware Cooperative Extension, Mint fact sheet: lists *Mentha* spp., spearmint and peppermint maturity around 60-70 days, and common pest/disease concerns.
- University of Maryland Extension, Growing Mint in a Home Garden: describes peppermint and spearmint differences and general mint growing conditions.
- Illinois Extension, Mint: notes peppermint and spearmint commonly grow 1-3 ft tall and spread aggressively by underground rhizomes.
- North Carolina Extension Gardener Plant Toolbox, *Mentha x piperita* and *Mentha spicata*: growth habits, container control, and pest/disease issues.
- UC IPM Mint: mint pest-management guidance and cultural care notes.